AI Max for Search

Microsoft Advertising vs Google Ads

A simple, explanatory partner guide

Both platforms use AI to expand query matching, tailor ad messages and route users to relevant landing pages. The important difference is how each platform gives advertisers control, visibility and a way to validate results.

Purpose of this guide

This document explains the products in business language rather than presenting a long feature checklist. It can be used as a discussion aid with partners or advertisers evaluating AI-powered Search.

At a glance

- Microsoft AI Max is an optional feature layer within standard Search campaigns.
- Google AI Max is also an automation layer for Search, with some broader or more granular controls in selected areas.
- The correct recommendation is not to declare one platform universally better. The recommendation is to match the operating model to the advertiser's needs and prove value through testing.

1. What AI Max does

AI Max combines three connected forms of automation:

Capability	Plain-language explanation
Search term matching	Finds relevant searches beyond the advertiser's explicit keyword list by interpreting intent and campaign signals.
Text customization	Creates or adapts ad text using existing assets and website content to make the message more relevant.
Final URL expansion	Selects a more relevant landing page when another page on the website better matches the user's intent.

These components are designed to work together: broaden the opportunity, improve the message and send the user to the most useful destination.

What AI Max does not mean

- It does not remove normal auction eligibility, budgeting or targeting requirements.
- It does not guarantee additional impressions or conversions simply because it is enabled.
- It should not be evaluated after only a few days or while the campaign is being changed frequently.

2. What Microsoft and Google share

- AI-assisted expansion beyond traditional keyword coverage.
- Dynamic creative relevance based on available assets and web content.
- Landing-page selection designed to improve relevance.
- Controls intended to protect brand suitability and exclude unwanted traffic or language.
- Reporting that helps advertisers understand and optimize automated behavior.

The shared value proposition is orchestration across intent, message and destination.

3. The practical differences

The comparison below focuses on operating logic and partner decision-making, not marketing claims.

Decision area	Microsoft Advertising	Google Ads
Campaign structure	Optional capability inside standard Search campaigns; the familiar campaign structure remains.	Automation layer within Search, with a mature feature set and transition path from Dynamic Search Ads.
Control	Core budgets, bids, locations, schedules, negatives and conversion goals remain in place.	Some controls are broader or more granular, including selected ad-group-level and location-of-interest options.
Visibility	Strong partner story around asset, keyword, search-term, final-URL and landing-page reporting.	Strong reporting and optimization ecosystem, with details depending on feature and account availability.
Testing	Search Experiments support a clean AI Max on/off validation approach.	Experiments and platform measurement can also be used; setup logic differs.
Bidding	Microsoft guidance has emphasized conversion feedback for matching and URL expansion; support has evolved, so validate the account.	Broader bidding support in the current Google experience.
Import / migration	Google Import helps port campaigns, but imported behavior is not necessarily identical.	Google has announced a DSA-to-AI-Max upgrade path. Do not assume that path maps one-to-one to Microsoft.

Important:

Feature availability can vary by market, account and rollout stage. Confirm availability before using a capability as a client-facing proof point.

4. Where Microsoft has the strongest story

Visibility

Advertisers can inspect how automation is behaving across queries, assets and landing pages.

Familiar control

AI Max works within the boundaries of the existing Search setup instead of replacing the whole operating model.

Measurable adoption

A controlled experiment can isolate the impact of AI Max rather than relying on before-and-after impressions.

Continuity

Partners can extend an existing Search strategy rather than building a completely new campaign type.

5. Recommended way to adopt AI Max

1. Select

Choose a campaign with reliable conversion tracking, sufficient conversion volume, adequate budget and room to capture more intent.

2. Isolate

Use a controlled Search Experiment. Keep the treatment and control aligned, and change AI Max only.

3. Learn

Allow the campaign to stabilize. Monitor query relevance, generated messaging, landing-page behavior and conversion quality.

4. Scale

Apply the approach only when sustained incremental value supports the advertiser's CPA, ROAS or conversion objectives.

Avoid these mistakes

- Enabling AI Max everywhere without a measurement plan.
- Comparing short, unstable periods or changing bids and budgets during the test.
- Promising a traffic or performance uplift before the experiment has produced evidence.
- Presenting planned or rolling-out controls as universally available.